

Fixing Comma Splices — 9th Grade, 30 Minutes

Diagnose & Repair — Comma Splices

The Cover Test: Cover everything after the comma. Complete sentence? Cover everything before. Complete sentence there too? You have a comma splice. Fix it one of three ways:

- Add a **period** and start a new sentence.
- Swap the comma for a **semicolon**.
- Keep the comma and add a **conjunction** (and, but, so, yet, or, for, nor).

1. The new phone costs over a thousand dollars, most students can't afford it.

Which fix will you use? _____

Your corrected sentence:

2. Climate change affects coastal cities, many are investing in flood barriers.

Which fix will you use? _____

Your corrected sentence:

3. He wanted to try out for the team, he was nervous about the competition.

Which fix will you use? _____

Your corrected sentence:

4. She studied all night for the exam, she still felt unprepared.

Fix this one **two different ways** — use a different method each time.

Fix A:

Fix B:

Write Your Own

Write a sentence with two independent clauses, correctly joined with a comma and a conjunction. Then rewrite it using a semicolon instead.

Comma + conjunction version:

Semicolon version:

Find It in Your Own Writing

Open a piece of writing you have already done. Find one sentence you think might be a comma splice. Copy it here, then write the fix.

Original sentence:

Your fix:

Fixing Comma Splices

Slides — 11 slides · 29 min · English 9

1. Fixing Comma Splices · 1 min

One rule. Three fixes. Five seconds each.

Notes: Let the starter writing settle, then put this on the wall. Tell them: 'A comma splice is one of the most common errors in student writing — and one of the fastest to fix once you see it.' That is the whole pitch. Move on.

2. Here is a comma splice · 1 min

The album dropped at midnight, fans crashed the streaming servers.

Notes: Read it aloud. Ask: 'Does anything feel off?' Take two or three responses. Do not confirm or deny yet — you want them leaning in before you name the rule.

3. The rule · 1 min

A comma splice happens when two complete sentences are joined with only a comma. A comma is not strong enough to hold two full sentences together.

Notes: Keep this short. The rule is simple; the examples do the teaching. Say: 'Two full sentences need something stronger than a comma. You have three options.' Then move to the fixes.

4. Three fixes · 1 min

- Period — split them into two sentences.
- Semicolon — connect them without a conjunction.
- Comma + conjunction — add and, but, so, or yet.

Notes: Point to each fix and say the name clearly. Tell them: 'All three are correct. The one you choose depends on the meaning you want.' Leave this slide up while you work through the examples.

5. Fix 1 — Add a conjunction · 2 min

Splice — The album dropped at midnight, fans crashed the streaming servers.

Fixed — The album dropped at midnight, and fans crashed the streaming servers.

Notes: Ask: 'What changed?' Draw out that 'and' was added — the comma stays, but now it has a partner. Ask why 'and' fits here rather than 'but' or 'so'. There is a real answer: the two events happen together, not in contrast.

6. Fix 2 — Use a semicolon · 2 min

Splice — The coach called a timeout, the players were exhausted.

Fixed — The coach called a timeout; the players were exhausted.

Notes: Say: 'A semicolon works when the two ideas are closely related and you want them to feel connected without spelling out how.' Ask: 'Why does this feel different from using a period here?' The semicolon implies cause; the period just stops.

7. Fix 3 — Use a period · 1 min

Splice — I finished my essay early, I decided to revise it one more time.

Fixed — I finished my essay early. I decided to revise it one more time.

Notes: Say: 'Sometimes the cleanest fix is just a period. Two sentences, two periods, done.' Ask: 'When would you choose a period over a semicolon?' Guide them toward: when the ideas are less tightly linked, or when the pause feels right.

8. The Cover Test · 2 min

- Cover everything after the comma. Is it a complete sentence?
- Cover everything before the comma. Complete sentence there too?
- Both yes? You have a splice. Pick your fix.

Notes: Model this physically — use your hand to cover part of the sentence on screen. Then do it once more with a new example: 'She was tired, she kept reading.' Have students call out the answer before you reveal it. This is the tool they will use on the handout.

9. Pair repair · 8 min

Work with your partner. Apply the Cover Test to each sentence on the handout. Write the fix — and say which method you used.

Notes: Distribute the Diagnose & Repair handout now. Give pairs about 7 minutes. Circulate: listen for the Cover Test being used aloud, and watch for pairs who fix the splice but pick a conjunction that changes the meaning — that is worth stopping the room for briefly.

10. Yawp practice · 5 min

Open Yawp and complete the comma splice practice set. Choose the fix that fits the meaning — not just any fix that is technically correct.

Notes: Students work individually and silently. This should take about 5 minutes. If anyone finishes early, send them to the 'Write Your Own' item on the handout.

11. Before you go · 5 min

Complete the exit ticket in Yawp. Then find one possible splice in your own writing and write the fix on the back of the handout.

Notes: Give them 2 minutes for the ticket, then 2 for the repair hunt. Collect the handout at the door. The repair-in-their-own-writing is the real transfer check — what they hand you tells you more than the exercises did.